Later that month—on the fifteenth, to be exact—I picked up a little gray female kitten, three months old. I hadn't had a cat since my single days and I wasn't sure how Gertrude would feel about it. I was delighted to discover that she was as fond of cats as I was.

I tried to call it "Smoky," but Gertrude called it "Putchikl," a kind of Yiddish distortion of "Pussy," and Putchikl it became.

It was a sweet and gentle little cat. We kept its box down in the cellar and it went down there when nature called. We kept it in the cellar (which connected directly with our apartment) when we wanted it out of the way, but if at any time we opened the door and called "Putchikl!" it came running upstairs with some of the sound effects of a team of galloping horses.

In the warm weather, we let it stay in the backyard sometimes, but it quickly learned how to open the window screen from the outside and make its way inside. This could be disconcerting, for when we had it outside overnight it would make its way in at dawn and get into bed with us.

If it merely cuddled down somewhere against our bodies that would have been all right. We wouldn't have minded. Sometimes, though, for some cat reason of its own, it would decide to gaze earnestly into our faces (usually Gertrude's) and wait for us to wake up. The effect of opening one's eyes blearily and finding the whole field of view from end to end filled with a cat's face is a startling one.

Since we fed Putchild well, it never developed the need to behave as a predator. Once (on May 3, 1948, actually) a little mouse appeared in the kitchen and Gertrude, becoming aware of it, left in a hurry and closed the door. She consulted me, but I was a broken reed. I couldn't imagine what one did to get rid of a mouse, except, perhaps speak crossly to it.

Then Gertrude said, "Putchikl! Of course!" We opened the cellar door and Putchikl came bounding up in great delight. She was snatched up and shoved through the kitchen door, which we opened for the purpose, then closed behind her. We then both listened for the sound of shrieks and screams and tearing flesh and crunching bones. Nothing!

Finally, not knowing what could possibly have happened, we opened the kitchen door a crack and peeked in. There was the mouse sitting in the middle of the floor, clearly the unconcerned ruler of the room, and there, on a chair and looking very uneasy, was Putchikl.